FAITHFUL IN GOD'S HOUSEHOLD · SESSION 1

Guard the Gospel

1 Timothy 1:1–20

TO GET STARTED

Think of something precious someone once entrusted to you – a key, a child, a secret. How did it change the way you behaved?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Paul has left Timothy behind in Ephesus, a busy port city full of temples and ideas, to deal with people who were teaching “a different doctrine”. This letter is Paul's instruction for how the church should live as God's household. Tonight we read chapter 1: the danger of false teaching, Paul's own story of grace, and a charge to Timothy to stay in the fight.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 1:1–4

1 Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the command of God our Saviour and of Christ
Jesus our hope, 2 to Timothy, my true child in the faith: grace, mercy and peace
from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord.

3 As I urged you when I was going on to Macedonia, stay on in Ephesus, so that you
may instruct certain people not to teach a different doctrine 4 and not to occupy
themselves with myths and endless genealogies, which produce speculations rather
than God's ordering of things, which is by faith –

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 1:5–9

5 but the goal of our instruction is love from a pure heart, from a good conscience
and from a sincere faith. 6 Some have strayed from these and have turned aside to
empty talk. 7 They want to be teachers of the law, without understanding either
what they are saying or the things about which they make such confident claims.
8 Now we know that the law is good, if one uses it lawfully, 9 knowing this: the law is
not laid down for the righteous, but for the lawless and rebellious, for the ungodly
and sinners, for the unholy and profane, for those who kill their fathers or their
mothers, for murderers,

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 1:10–14

10 for the sexually immoral, for men who have sex with men, for slave traders, for
liars, for perjurers, and for whatever else is contrary to sound teaching, 11 in keeping
with the gospel of the glory of the blessed God, which was entrusted to me.

12 I give thanks to him who has strengthened me, Christ Jesus our Lord, because he
judged me faithful and appointed me to his service, 13 though I was formerly a
blasphemer, a persecutor and a violent man. But I was shown mercy, because I
acted in ignorance and unbelief. 14 And the grace of our Lord overflowed, together
with the faith and love that are in Christ Jesus.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 1:15–17

15 This is a trustworthy saying and deserves full acceptance: Christ Jesus came into
the world to save sinners – and of them I am the first. 16 But for this very reason I was
shown mercy: so that in me, as the first, Christ Jesus might display his complete
patience, as an example for those who were going to believe in him for eternal life.

17 Now to the King of the ages,
the imperishable, invisible, only God,
be honour and glory for ever and ever. Amen.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 1:18–20

18 This instruction I entrust to you, Timothy, my child, in keeping with the
prophecies once made about you, so that by them you may wage the good warfare,
19 holding on to faith and a good conscience. Some have pushed this conscience aside
and have made shipwreck of their faith. 20 Among them are Hymenaeus and
Alexander, whom I have handed over to Satan, so that they may be taught not to
blaspheme.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

τέλος τῆς παραγγελίας

telos tēs parangelias · "the goal of our instruction"

The goal of all teaching is not winning debates but "love from a pure heart, from a good conscience and from a sincere faith" (1:5). Teaching that breeds pride and quarrels has missed its goal.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

πιστὸς ὁ λόγος

pistos ho logos · "this is a trustworthy saying"

The first of five "trustworthy sayings" in the Pastoral Letters (1:15). It anchors the church in a simple confession: "Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners."

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

στρατεία

strateia · "warfare"

Timothy is to "wage the good warfare" (1:18) – a long military campaign, not a single battle. Faith and a good conscience are his equipment; without them faith suffers shipwreck.

THE BIG IDEA

Sound teaching is known by its fruit – love, a good conscience and sincere faith – and at its heart stands the gospel of grace for sinners like Paul and like us.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

What were the false teachers in Ephesus busy with, according to verses 3–7? What might “myths and endless genealogies” look like in church life today?

1 Timothy 1:3–7

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Paul says the goal of instruction is “love from a pure heart, from a good conscience and from a sincere faith”. How can we tell whether teaching we hear is “sound”?

1 Timothy 1:5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Paul describes himself as “a blasphemer, a persecutor and a violent man”. Why do you think he tells his own story at this point in the letter?

1 Timothy 1:13

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Paul says “of them I am the first” – present tense, not past. What does this tell us about how a mature Christian sees himself or herself?

1 Timothy 1:15

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Paul's testimony ends in worship (v. 17). When did thinking about God's grace last lead you to praise?

1 Timothy 1:17

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“Some have pushed this conscience aside and have made shipwreck of their faith.” How can ignoring our conscience slowly wreck our faith?

1 Timothy 1:19

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Where is your conscience “flashing a warning light” at the moment? Share only what you are comfortable sharing.

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Write down your own short “testimony of grace” (three or four sentences, as Paul does in verses 12–16) and share it with one person this week.
- Ask God each evening this week: “Is there anything I am pushing aside in my conscience?” – and act on one thing he shows you.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading 1:17 aloud together as praise. Then pray in pairs: thank God for his mercy to each of you, and pray for people you know who have “made shipwreck” of their faith, that they would be restored.

FAITHFUL IN GOD'S HOUSEHOLD · SESSION 2

Prayer for All, Worship in Order

1 Timothy 2:1–15

TO GET STARTED

Who is a public figure – a politician, a celebrity, a CEO – you find hard to pray for? (No need to say why.)

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

After warning against false teaching, Paul turns to the life of the church gathered for worship. First he urges prayer for all people, including rulers, because there is one God and one mediator. Then he speaks to men and women about how they pray, dress, learn and serve – some of the most discussed verses in the New Testament.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 2:1–5

1 First of all, then, I urge that petitions, prayers, intercessions and thanksgivings be
made for all people, 2 for kings and all who are in high positions, so that we may lead
a peaceful and quiet life in all godliness and dignity. 3 This is good and pleasing
before God our Saviour, 4 who wants all people to be saved and to come to the
knowledge of the truth.

5 For there is one God,
and there is one mediator between God and humankind,
the man Christ Jesus,

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 2:6–9

6 who gave himself as a ransom for all –
the testimony at the proper time.
7 For this I was appointed a herald and an apostle – I am telling the truth, I am not lying – a teacher of the nations in faith and truth.

8 I want the men, then, to pray in every place, lifting up holy hands without anger or quarrelling. 9 Likewise also the women should adorn themselves in respectable clothing, with modesty and self-control, not with braided hair and gold or pearls or expensive clothing,

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 2:10–15

10 but – as is fitting for women who profess reverence for God – with good works. 11 A
woman should learn in quietness, in all submission. 12 I do not permit a woman to
teach, nor to exercise authority over a man; she is to be in quietness. 13 For Adam
was formed first, then Eve. 14 And Adam was not deceived, but the woman was
deceived and fell into transgression. 15 But she will be saved through childbearing, if
they remain in faith and love and holiness, with self-control.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

μεσίτης

mesitēs · “mediator”

A mediator stands between two estranged parties to reconcile them. There is “one mediator between God and humankind, the man Christ Jesus” (2:5) – no other bridge is needed or possible.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀντίλυτρον

antilytron · “ransom”

Christ “gave himself as a ransom for all” (2:6). The prefix anti- means “in the place of”: our freedom was bought at the cost of his own life.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἡσυχία

hēsychia · "quietness"

The same root as the "peaceful and quiet life" Paul wants for all believers (2:2). In 2:11–12 it describes a peaceful, teachable spirit – not a humiliating silence.

THE BIG IDEA

God “wants all people to be saved”, so the church's first task is prayer for all – and its worship should reflect reconciled hearts, holy lives and God's good order.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Paul lists “petitions, prayers, intercessions and thanksgivings”. Which of these is strongest in your prayer life, and which is weakest?

1 Timothy 2:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Why does Paul link praying for rulers with God, “who wants all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth”?

1 Timothy 2:1–4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Read verses 5–6 again. What difference does it make in daily life that there is only one mediator?

1 Timothy 2:5–6

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Men are to pray “lifting up holy hands without anger or quarrelling”. How can unresolved anger block our prayers?

1 Timothy 2:8

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Paul contrasts outward adornment with “good works”. Where do we invest more – in our image or in our character?

1 Timothy 2:9–10

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Paul says “A woman should learn” – in its culture a remarkable command. What do verses 11–15 say, and what do they not say? Listen carefully to one another here.

1 Timothy 2:11–15

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Whom do you find hardest to pray for – and what would change if you prayed for them regularly?

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one political leader and one person you disagree with, and pray for each of them by name every day this week.
- If there is anger or a quarrel between you and someone else, take one step towards reconciliation before next week.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray around the circle for leaders in your town, country and the world, using the four kinds of prayer from verse 1. Close by saying verses 5–6 together as a confession of faith.

FAITHFUL IN GOD'S HOUSEHOLD · SESSION 3

Leaders for God's Household

1 Timothy 3:1–16

TO GET STARTED

If you had to hire someone to look after your house and family while you were away for a year, what would matter most to you?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

The crisis in Ephesus was at heart a leadership crisis. In chapter 3 Paul sets out what overseers and deacons must be like – almost all of it about character, very little about skills. Then he explains why: the church is the household of the living God, and he ends with an early Christian hymn about Christ.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 3:1–5

[1] This is a trustworthy saying: if anyone aspires to the office of overseer, he desires a good work. [2] The overseer, then, must be above reproach, the husband of one wife, sober-minded, self-controlled, respectable, hospitable, able to teach, [3] not a drunkard, not violent but gentle, not quarrelsome, not a lover of money, [4] one who manages his own household well and keeps his children in submission, with all dignity – [5] for if someone does not know how to manage his own household, how will he take care of God's church? –

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 3:6–11

6 not a recent convert, so that he does not become conceited and fall into the
condemnation of the devil. 7 He must also have a good reputation with outsiders, so
that he does not fall into disgrace and into the devil's trap. 8 Deacons likewise must
be dignified, not double-tongued, not given to much wine, not greedy for dishonest
gain, 9 holding the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience. 10 And let them also
be tested first; then let them serve, if they prove blameless. 11 Women likewise must
be dignified, not slanderers, sober-minded, faithful in all things.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 3:12–16

12 Deacons must each be the husband of one wife, managing their children and their
own households well. 13 For those who have served well gain a good standing for
themselves and great confidence in the faith that is in Christ Jesus.

14 I am writing these things to you, though I hope to come to you soon, 15 so that, if I
am delayed, you may know how one ought to behave in the household of God,
which is the church of the living God, a pillar and foundation of the truth. 16 And
beyond all question, great is the mystery of godliness:

He was revealed in the flesh,
vindicated by the Spirit,
seen by angels,
proclaimed among the nations,
believed in throughout the world,
taken up in glory.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀνεπίλημπτος

anepilēmptos · “above reproach”

The heading over the whole list (3:2): a picture from wrestling – someone with nothing an opponent can grab hold of. Not sinless, but without obvious footholds for accusation.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

δοκιμάζω

dokimazō · "be tested"

Of deacons Paul says: "let them also be tested first" (3:10) – the word for testing precious metals in fire. Character is proved over time, before a public task is given.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

εὐσέβεια

eusebeia · “godliness”

The letter's key word. “great is the mystery of godliness” (3:16): true godliness is not produced by willpower, it flows from wonder at who Christ is and what he has done.

THE BIG IDEA

The church is God's household and “a pillar and foundation of the truth”, so its leaders are chosen for tested character more than talent – and all godliness flows from the mystery of Christ.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Read through the qualities in verses 2–7. How many are about skills, and how many about character? What does that tell us?

1 Timothy 3:2–7

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Why is the way someone manages his own household a test for leading “God's church”?

1 Timothy 3:4–5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Why should a leader “have a good reputation with outsiders”? How do colleagues and neighbours see our church – and us?

1 Timothy 3:7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Deacons are to be “not double-tongued”. Why is consistency in our words so important in a church family?

1 Timothy 3:8

DISCUSSION · 5/7

The church is “the household of God … a pillar and foundation of the truth”. Do we treat our local church more like a household or like a service provider?

1 Timothy 3:15

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Read the hymn in verse 16 slowly. Which line speaks to you most today, and why?

1 Timothy 3:16

DISCUSSION · 7/7

These qualities are for leaders, but they describe every mature Christian. Which one would you like God to grow in you?

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Pray this week for the leaders of your church by name, using one quality from verses 2–13 for each of them.
- Take on one quiet, unseen task of service in your church or home this week, without telling anyone.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray for the overseers, elders and deacons of your church. Then read the hymn of verse 16 aloud once more and turn each line into a short sentence of praise.

FAITHFUL IN GOD'S HOUSEHOLD · SESSION 4

Training for Godliness

1 Timothy 4:1–16

TO GET STARTED

What is something you have trained for – a sport, an instrument, a language? What did it take to keep going when it got boring?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 3 ended with the hymn to Christ, “the mystery of godliness”. Chapter 4 now shows its counterfeit: teachers in Ephesus who forbid marriage and certain foods and call that holiness. Against them Paul sets two things – thankful enjoyment of God's good creation, and a young leader who trains himself for godliness and keeps watch over his own life.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 4:1–5

1 Now the Spirit says explicitly that in later times some will fall away from the faith,
devoting themselves to deceiving spirits and teachings of demons, 2 through the
hypocrisy of liars whose own consciences have been branded. 3 They forbid
marriage and demand abstinence from foods that God created to be received with
thanksgiving by those who believe and know the truth. 4 For everything created by
God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving, 5 for it
is made holy by the word of God and prayer.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 4:6–9

6 If you put these things before the brothers and sisters, you will be a good servant of
Christ Jesus, nourished on the words of the faith and of the good teaching that you
have followed. 7 But have nothing to do with irreverent, old wives' myths. Rather,
train yourself for godliness. 8 For bodily training is of little value, but godliness is of
value in every way, holding promise for the present life and for the life to come.
9 This is a trustworthy saying and deserves full acceptance.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 4:10–14

10 For to this end we toil and are reviled, because we have set our hope on the living
God, who is the Saviour of all people, especially of those who believe.

11 Instruct people in these things and teach them. 12 Let no one look down on you
because of your youth, but set the believers an example in speech, in conduct, in
love, in faith, in purity. 13 Until I come, devote yourself to the public reading of
Scripture, to exhortation and to teaching. 14 Do not neglect the gift that is in you,
which was given to you through prophecy when the council of elders laid their
hands on you.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 4:15–16

15 Put these things into practice, give yourself wholly to them, so that your progress
may be evident to all. 16 Keep a close watch on yourself and on your teaching; persist
in them. For by doing this you will save both yourself and those who hear you.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

γύμναζε σεαυτὸν πρὸς εὐσέβειαν

gymnazō · “train yourself for godliness”

The word that gives us “gymnasium”. Godliness is not a feeling that falls on us but something trained with regular, sometimes sweaty effort (4:7) – and unlike bodily training, it pays off in both this life and the next (4:8).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

κεκαυστηριασμένων τὴν ἰδίαν συνείδησιν

kekaustēriasmenōn · “whose own consciences have been branded”

A conscience seared as with a branding iron no longer feels anything (4:2). The false teachers could sound very strict and still be dead inside.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

τύπος

typos · "example"

Timothy's answer to people who look down on his youth is not a title but a life that others can copy: "in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity" (4:12).

THE BIG IDEA

False piety says “Don't touch” and makes people anxious; true godliness receives God's good gifts with thanksgiving and is trained day by day – in the leader's own life first.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

What exactly did the false teachers forbid, and what is Paul's answer? Look closely at verses 3 to 5.

1 Timothy 4:3–5

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving.” Where do Christians today still make holiness a matter of avoiding things rather than receiving them gratefully?

1 Timothy 4:4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Paul says, “Rather, train yourself for godliness.” What would a realistic “training plan” for godliness look like in your week?

1 Timothy 4:7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Bodily training is of “little value”, godliness of value “in every way”. Where do our time and money show what we really value more?

1 Timothy 4:8

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“Let no one look down on you because of your youth.” What does Paul tell Timothy to do instead of demanding respect? What could that mean for younger people in our church – and for how older people treat them?

1 Timothy 4:12

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Paul names reading Scripture aloud, exhortation and teaching (4:13). Which of these is strongest in our group, and which do we neglect?

1 Timothy 4:13

DISCUSSION · 7/7

“Keep a close watch on yourself and on your teaching.” Why do both belong together? Where is it easier for you to watch one and neglect the other?

1 Timothy 4:16

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one small, daily “exercise” of godliness for this week (for example, ten minutes of Scripture before your phone, or thanksgiving before every meal) and tell one person in the group which one.
- Pay attention to one good gift of God you usually take for granted – food, rest, a relationship – and receive it this week consciously “with thanksgiving”.

PRAY TOGETHER

Thank God together for his good gifts, naming specific ones. Then pray in pairs for each other's “training” in godliness, and for younger people in the church who serve or are just starting to serve.

FAITHFUL IN GOD'S HOUSEHOLD · SESSION 5

The Church as a Family

1 Timothy 5:1–25

TO GET STARTED

Who was a “spiritual father” or “spiritual mother” to you – someone outside your own family who shaped your faith? What did they do?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Paul has called the church “the household of God” (3:15). In chapter 5 he shows what that means in everyday life: how to speak to older and younger people, how to look after widows who have no one, and how to treat elders – with honour, but also with fair correction. It is the most practical chapter of the letter, and some of it is far from our world; the principles behind it are not.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 5:1–6

[1] Do not rebuke an older man harshly, but encourage him as you would a father,
younger men as brothers, [2] older women as mothers, younger women as sisters, in
all purity.

[3] Honour widows who are truly widows. [4] But if a widow has children or
grandchildren, let them first learn to show godliness towards their own household
and to repay their parents, for this is pleasing before God. [5] The one who is truly a
widow and left all alone has set her hope on God and continues in petitions and
prayers night and day. [6] But the one who lives for pleasure is dead while she lives.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 5:7–10

7 Instruct them in these things too, so that they may be above reproach. 8 But if
anyone does not provide for his own relatives, and especially for members of his
household, he has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever. 9 Let a widow be
put on the list if she is not less than sixty years old, the wife of one husband, 10 and
well known for good works: if she has brought up children, if she has shown
hospitality, if she has washed the feet of the saints, if she has helped the afflicted, if
she has devoted herself to every good work.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 5:11–15

11 But refuse younger widows; for when their desires draw them away from Christ,
they want to marry, 12 and so incur condemnation for having set aside their first
faithfulness. 13 Besides that, they learn to be idle, going round from house to house;
and not only idle, but also gossips and busybodies, saying what they should not.
14 So I want younger widows to marry, to have children, to manage their
households, and to give the adversary no occasion for slander. 15 For some have
already turned aside to follow Satan.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 5:16–20

16 If any believing woman has widows in her family, let her help them, and let the
church not be burdened, so that it may help those who are truly widows.

17 Let the elders who lead well be considered worthy of double honour, especially
those who labour in preaching and teaching. 18 For the Scripture says, "You shall not
muzzle an ox while it is treading out the grain," and, "The worker deserves his
wages." 19 Do not accept an accusation against an elder except on the evidence of two
or three witnesses. 20 Those who persist in sin, rebuke in the presence of all, so that
the rest may also stand in fear.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 5:21–25

21 I solemnly charge you before God and Christ Jesus and the chosen angels to keep
these rules without prejudice, doing nothing out of favouritism. 22 Do not be hasty
in the laying on of hands, and do not take part in the sins of others. Keep yourself
pure. 23 No longer drink only water, but use a little wine for the sake of your
stomach and your frequent illnesses. 24 The sins of some people are obvious, going
ahead of them to judgement, but the sins of others follow after them. 25 So also good
works are obvious, and even those that are not cannot remain hidden.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

τὰς ὄντως χήρας

ontōs chēra · "truly widows"

Paul uses this phrase three times (5:3, 5, 16). The church's help is meant first for those who really have no one else – families are to take responsibility for their own first (5:4, 8).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

μὴ ἐπιπλήξῃς, ἀλλὰ παρακάλει

parakalei · “do not rebuke … harshly, but encourage”

Even necessary correction is to happen in a family tone: an older man as a father, younger men as brothers (5:1). The word for “encourage” comes from the same root as the Holy Spirit's name, the Paraclete.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

διπλῆς τιμῆς

diplē timē · “double honour”

Elders who lead well and labour in preaching and teaching deserve respect and also practical support (5:17–18) – and when they sin, they are not exempt from correction (5:19–20).

THE BIG IDEA

God's household is a family: we treat each other as fathers, mothers, brothers and sisters, care concretely for those who are truly alone, and honour and correct leaders fairly and without favouritism.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

How should Timothy speak to older men, younger men, older women and younger women? What changes if we really treat the church as a family?

1 Timothy 5:1–2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“Honour widows who are truly widows.” Who are the people in our church and town today who are “truly alone”? How would we know?

1 Timothy 5:3

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Paul is very sharp in verse 8: whoever does not provide for his own relatives “has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever”. Why does care for our own families weigh so heavily?

1 Timothy 5:8

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The widows on the list were known for hospitality, washing the feet of the saints and helping the afflicted (5:10). What does this list tell us about what God values in a life?

1 Timothy 5:10

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Elders are “worthy of double honour”, yet accusations need two or three witnesses, and sin is rebuked openly (5:17–20). How can a church honour its leaders and still hold them accountable?

1 Timothy 5:17–20

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“Do not be hasty in the laying on of hands.” Why is patience so important before trusting people with leadership? Have you seen what happens without it?

1 Timothy 5:22

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Paul tells Timothy to look after his health (5:23). What does it say about God that such a practical remark stands in the middle of instructions for church leaders?

1 Timothy 5:23

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Think of one older person and one younger person in the church you could treat this week as a “father/mother” or “brother/sister” – with a call, a visit or a meal.
- Find out together whether there is someone in your church or neighbourhood who is “truly alone”, and agree on one concrete step of help.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray for people in the church who are alone, ill or grieving, by name where appropriate. Then pray for the elders and leaders of your church: for wisdom, protection and faithfulness.

FAITHFUL IN GOD'S HOUSEHOLD · SESSION 6

Real Wealth, Real Life

1 Timothy 6:1–21

TO GET STARTED

If your house were on fire and everyone were safe, what one thing would you go back for – and why?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In the last chapter Paul gathers up the letter. He contrasts teachers who see godliness as “a means of gain” with the real gain of contentment, calls Timothy a “man of God” with four commands – flee, pursue, fight, take hold – breaks out into praise of the King of kings, and ends with one urgent plea: guard what has been entrusted to you.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 6:1–3

[1] Let all who are under the yoke as slaves regard their own masters as worthy of all
honour, so that the name of God and the teaching may not be blasphemed. [2] Those
who have believing masters must not look down on them because they are
brothers; rather, they must serve them all the better, because those who benefit
from their good service are believers and beloved. Teach and urge these things.

[3] If anyone teaches a different doctrine and does not agree with the sound words of
our Lord Jesus Christ and with the teaching that accords with godliness,

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 6:4–8

4 he is puffed up and understands nothing. He has an unhealthy craving for
controversies and quarrels about words, which produce envy, strife, slander, evil
suspicions, 5 and constant friction among people who are corrupted in mind and
deprived of the truth, who think that godliness is a means of gain. 6 But godliness
with contentment is great gain. 7 For we brought nothing into the world, and we
cannot take anything out of it. 8 But if we have food and clothing, with these we will
be content.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 6:9–12

9 But those who want to be rich fall into temptation, into a trap, and into many
senseless and harmful desires that plunge people into ruin and destruction. 10 For
the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil. Some, by craving it, have wandered
away from the faith and pierced themselves with many pains.

11 But you, man of God, flee from these things. Pursue righteousness, godliness,
faith, love, endurance, gentleness. 12 Fight the good fight of the faith. Take hold of
the eternal life to which you were called and about which you made the good
confession in the presence of many witnesses.

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 6:13–15

13 I charge you before God, who gives life to all things, and before Christ Jesus, who
in his testimony before Pontius Pilate made the good confession, 14 to keep the
commandment spotless and above reproach until the appearing of our Lord Jesus
Christ,

15 which he will display at the proper time –
he who is the blessed and only Sovereign,
the King of kings and Lord of lords,

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 6:16–18

16 who alone has immortality,
who dwells in unapproachable light,
whom no one has ever seen or can see.
To him be honour and eternal dominion. Amen.
17 As for the rich in this present age, instruct them not to be arrogant, nor to set
their hope on the uncertainty of riches, but on God, who richly provides us with
everything to enjoy. 18 They are to do good, to be rich in good works, to be generous
and ready to share,

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 6:19–21

19 so storing up for themselves a good foundation for the future, so that they may
take hold of the life that is truly life.

20 O Timothy, guard what has been entrusted to you. Turn away from irreverent,
empty chatter and the contradictions of what is falsely called knowledge, 21 which
some have professed and so have swerved from the faith. Grace be with you all.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

αὐτάρκεια

autarkeia · “contentment”

In Stoic philosophy, the pride of needing nothing. Paul fills it with new content: being satisfied with what God gives, because he is enough (6:6–8).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

φιλαργυρία

philargyria · "love of money"

Not money itself, but the love of it is “a root of all kinds of evil” (6:10). It quietly draws people away from the faith and leaves them “pierced … with many pains”.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

τὴν παραθήκην φύλαξον

parathēkē · “guard what has been entrusted to you”

A deposit handed over for safekeeping: the keeper may not change it or keep it for himself, but must protect it and pass it on intact (6:20). That is how Paul sees the gospel.

THE BIG IDEA

True gain is godliness with contentment; so flee the love of money, pursue Christlike character, fight the good fight of the faith – and guard the gospel entrusted to you.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Verses 1 and 2 speak to slaves in the Roman world. We live in a different world, but most of us work under someone's authority. What does it look like to work in a way that brings honour, not shame, to “the name of God”?

1 Timothy 6:1–2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Some people think “that godliness is a means of gain”. Where do we see this today – and where in ourselves?

1 Timothy 6:5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“But godliness with contentment is great gain.” What makes contentment so hard in our culture? What helps you practise it?

1 Timothy 6:6–8

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil.” How can you recognise when love of money is growing in your own heart?

1 Timothy 6:10

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Flee, pursue, fight, take hold (6:11–12). Which of the four commands is most urgent for you at the moment?

1 Timothy 6:11–12

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Paul tells the rich not to set their hope on “the uncertainty of riches, but on God, who richly provides us with everything to enjoy”. Compared with most of the world, many of us are rich. What would “rich in good works” look like for us?

1 Timothy 6:17–19

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Looking back over the six sessions: what has God shown you through 1 Timothy, and what will you take with you?

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Do a simple “contentment check” this week: each evening, write down three things God has given you that day, and one thing you can give away.
- Choose one concrete act of generosity – time, money or hospitality – and do it before the week is over, quietly.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading 6:15–16 aloud together as praise. Then pray for each other to “take hold of the life that is truly life”, and thank God for what the group has received through this study of 1 Timothy.